

Meeting Overview: Red Hat & Hershey Innovation and Infrastructure Strategy Session

Detailed Notes

- **RHEL & Satellite Infrastructure**
- **Current State:** Hershey has largely standardized on Red Hat Enterprise Linux (RHEL) 9 and is migrating away from older versions like RHEL 7 and 8 1-4. They currently manage their environments with Satellite and are looking forward to the High Availability (HA) features coming in Satellite 6.20 5-7.
- **Image Mode (Bootc):** Red Hat introduced RHEL 10's "Image Mode," which allows managing OS images like containers 8, 9. Initially, the Hershey team felt this was overcomplicated for standard workloads and pushed back on calling it a "container" 10-12. However, they recognized significant potential for their edge environments, specifically the "Connected Worker" program deployed across manufacturing plants. Image mode would allow them to deploy immutable appliances, improving security and standardizing plant deployments 13, 14.
- **Automation & Ansible Automation Platform (AAP)**
- **Current State:** Hershey's automation is currently disjointed. They use open-source Ansible via GitLab runners and rely heavily on custom scripts 15-18. A previous attempt to adopt AAP stalled due to the high cost of licensing every network device 19.
- **Event-Driven Ansible (EDA):** Red Hat demoed EDA, which resonated strongly with the Hershey team. Hershey's vision is to integrate their Dynatrace observability tool with ServiceNow and Ansible so that alerts automatically trigger remediation playbooks, log the incident in ServiceNow, and close the ticket upon resolution 20-23.
- **ServiceNow Integration:** Red Hat showcased how EDA can monitor ServiceNow catalog requests and automatically execute infrastructure deployments (e.g., adding an F5 load balancer node) without needing heavy custom backend development in ServiceNow 24-27. Hershey sees this as a major win to bypass long feedback loops with their ServiceNow developers 28.
- **OpenShift & Cluster Management**
- **Current State:** Hershey runs 12 OpenShift clusters, primarily serving as endpoints for their MuleSoft environment 29, 30. The team feels OpenShift is highly resource-intensive (e.g., dedicating 100+ cores just for worker nodes) and overkill for their current use case 31, 32. They plan to consolidate down to roughly 4 clusters (Non-prod, Prod East, Prod West) 33.
- **Advanced Cluster Management (ACM):** Red Hat highlighted ACM—which Hershey is already entitled to—as a way to manage their cluster fleet from a single pane of glass 34-36. ACM would also allow them to use hosted control planes, significantly reducing the hardware overhead required for each cluster 36.
- **Databases (Oracle & MS SQL)**
- **Oracle Licensing:** Hershey is currently stuck running Oracle databases on SPARC hardware because virtualizing it on Nutanix would require licensing all 4,000 cores in the cluster 37-39. Red Hat proposed running Oracle in containers on a dedicated OpenShift cluster to fence off the compute resources and avoid full-cluster licensing costs 40-42.

- **MS SQL:** Hershey manages roughly 4,000 Microsoft SQL Server databases. Red Hat pitched a Database-as-a-Service (DBaaS) architecture on OpenShift to help modernize and consolidate this footprint 43-45.
- **AI & Lightspeed:**
- Red Hat previewed "Lightspeed" AI assistants across their portfolio. Hershey sees immediate value in using these AI tools to rapidly onboard and train new developers in their Global Capability Center (GCC) 46-49.

Next Steps

For Red Hat:

- **Commercials & Pricing:** Provide updated pricing and a commercial proposal for the Ansible Automation Platform (AAP) to justify the business case for replacing Hershey's community Ansible setup 50, 51.
- **Oracle Licensing Research:** Investigate the specific contractual details around fencing Oracle licenses on OpenShift/virtualized clusters to help Hershey safely migrate off SPARC hardware 52-55.
- **Database-as-a-Service Follow-Up:** Coordinate a follow-up session/demo focusing specifically on Database-as-a-Service (DBaaS) on OpenShift for Microsoft SQL and PostgreSQL 45, 56, 57.

For Hershey:

- **Evaluate OpenShift ACM:** Deploy and test Advanced Cluster Management (ACM) using current entitlements to centralize management of the OpenShift fleet and explore hosted control planes for resource savings 36, 58.
- **OpenShift Consolidation:** Continue planning the architectural shift to reduce the OpenShift footprint from 12 clusters down to 4 33.
- **Bootc Edge Proof of Concept:** Explore using RHEL 10 Image Mode (Bootc) to create immutable OS images for the Connected Worker nodes deployed at the manufacturing plants 13, 14.